



Behold! It's a remake!

Anirudh "Mad Zombie" Regidi
anirudh.regidi@skoar.com

Before we begin, a disclaimer – This preview is written from the point-of-view of a DOTA n00b, someone who has just dabbled on the fringes of DOTA's allure, but was never quite smitten by the game.

Keeping that in mind, let's begin. Overall, the largest changes to the game seem to be from an aesthetic and functional stand-point. The first thing that you notice about DOTA 2 is the completely revamped interface. The game was primarily designed by Ice-Frog, the same dude who maintains DotA and is now working for Valve. The game also has an online marketplace where you can purchase various fancy looking items that have only a cosmetic effect on your character so far, which is good, as it still leaves the game balanced for non-paying members. Even so, paying \$12 (₹670) for a courier that looks like a frog instead of a donkey does seem a bit silly. Other items are not so expensive though and it might be worth spending a few dollars if you just want to set your character apart from the others.

Character selection

The new character portraits are a nice visual touch and we really liked the

playing card feel to the character selection menu. You can revert to a grid view any time you like and unlike DotA which had separate taverns for hero types, DOTA 2 combines all heroes on one page. Each hero has a nice improved 3D portrait, along with helpful information regarding what sort of hero you've chosen and even mini-tutorial videos demonstrating the hero's special abilities and skills. Very n00b-friendly we say!

Shopping

The shopping process has been vastly simplified in the game. There is now only one shop in your base (the secret shops and side shops are still present) and the shop can also be accessed any time by just hitting the "Shop" button any time within a game. The new interface for the shop is way better than the original. Clicking on any item will show you the entire recipe tree you can refer to and right-clicking on an item will purchase it outright, including all other items you may require, if you have the gold for it and if the shop you're at sells them. There is also a search bar as well as a "suggested items" box which contains recommended items for your character and also allows you to drag and drop items into it to customize your build. Other small changes, like the ability to resell within 10 seconds of purchase for full price are a nice addition.

Gameplay

The core gameplay doesn't seem to be affected in anyway and as mentioned in the beginning, the changes are largely cosmetic. Many of the in-game sounds are actually recycled from Valve's trademark sound effects, such as the button presses in Half-Life or the sound made by a recharge station. The characters also seem to have an entirely new repertoire of dialogue and are fun to listen to. Many of them are more tongue-in-cheek than in the original and are actually fun to listen to, you might just want to try out something new and whacky just to hear what your hero has to say.

Final thoughts

This remake of DOTA 2 by Valve is definitely one to watch out for. There are some things that detract from the experience, such as the sound effects associated with skill animations. Blizzard games tend toward the epic and Valve, well, has a dark and twisted sense of humour. This is most probably a result of the design philosophy of both studios and of course, players will have their own preferences and you will have fanboys and haters on both sides. The game is still in closed beta and needs a lot of work with regards to finishing touches and with the open beta scheduled to release soon, let us see where Valve intends to go with this cult-classic. *